

STUDENT-ATHLETE EXTREME HEAT AND PROTECTION

Loudoun County Public Schools (LCPS) provide evidence-based procedures to prevent, recognize, and respond to heat-related illnesses in student-athletes, committing to protecting their health and safety. This policy is developed in accordance with Code of Virginia §§ 22.1-271.9 and 22.1-271.10, guidance from the Virginia Department of Education (VDOE), and Virginia High School League (VHSL) regulations.

A. Environmental Monitoring and Tiered Procedures. Heat safety protocols are based on Wet Bulb Globe Temperature (WBGT). The Superintendent or designee shall ensure the implementation of tiered activity modifications based on WBGT thresholds.

1. Monitoring. WBGT will be measured at the site of play or practice before activity begins and rechecked at least every 30 minutes. Athletic Trainers are the primary medical professionals responsible for monitoring and guiding practice modifications. Coaches must adhere to modifications according to WBGT outlined in this policy.

- a. Tier 1 (Below 80.0°F). Full activity-specific equipment permitted; minimum of 3 water breaks per hour. Insist that adequate fluid be ingested.
- b. Tier 2 (80.0-82.4°F). Full activity-specific equipment permitted; minimum of 3 water breaks per hour. Insist 4-6 fluid ounces every 20 minutes.
- c. Tier 3 (82.5-84.9°F). Remove headgear (e.g., helmets, goalie helmets, catcher's masks, lacrosse helmets, shakos, or similar items) unless actively participating in drills requiring such equipment; minimum of 3 water breaks per hour. Insist 6-8 fluid ounces every 20 minutes.
- d. Tier 4 (85.0–87.4°F). No equipment during non-contact, low-intensity, or instructional periods exceeding 10 minutes; remove headgear unless actively participating in contact or high-intensity drills; minimum of 4 water breaks per hour. Insist 8-10 fluid ounces every 15 minutes.
- e. Tier 5 (87.5-89.9°F). No equipment-light attire only (e.g., shirts and shorts or activity-appropriate equivalent); reduce intensity of activity; minimum of 4 water breaks per hour. Insist 8-10 fluid ounces every 15 minutes.
- f. Tier 6 (Above 90.0°F). No outdoor practices, scrimmages, or competitions. Practices shall be conducted indoors and must follow

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the Heat Policy. Rehydrate 24 fluid ounces for every pound of body weight loss per day.

B. Prevention Protocols and Hydration.

1. Acclimatization. All student-athletes must undergo an acclimatization period at the start of each sports season, during which practice duration, intensity, and activity-specific equipment, and appropriate clothing are gradually adjusted to support safe participation.

2. Scheduling. Practices and conditioning sessions should be scheduled to avoid peak heat times whenever possible (early morning or evening). Double-session practices must include a minimum recovery period of one hour between sessions.

3. Hydration and Cooling Space. Each student-athlete must be given unhindered access at all times to hydration and a cooling space (shaded or air-conditioned).

4. Rapid Cooling Methods. Ice, water, and CWI tubs (or equivalent, e.g., TACO) required at WBGT $\geq 80^{\circ}\text{F}$.

C. Recognition and Emergency Treatment/Management.

1. Recognition. Staff responsible for athletic supervision shall be trained annually to recognize signs and symptoms of Dehydration, Heat Syncope, Heat Exhaustion, and Exertional Heat Stroke (EHS). EHS Management: EHS is a medical emergency. Any athlete suspected of EHS must be immediately removed from play, evaluated via rectal thermometry for core body temperature, and treated with rapid whole-body cooling, preferably cold-water immersion (CWI), until the temperature falls below 102°F (38.9°C). The "Cool First, Transport Second" protocol must be followed, requiring athletes to be cooled on-site prior to EMS transport.

D. Eligibility, Screening, and Return-to-Play.

1. Eligibility/Screening. Student-athletes must provide a current pre-participation physical examination form confirming medical clearance. Athletes should be screened for issues like recent cramping, weight changes, sickle cell trait, and other medical conditions.

- a. Prior Illness. Any history of prior exertional heat illness must be reported and reviewed by the school athletic trainer prior to clearance. Parents and guardians shall receive educational materials on heat illness prevention and management annually.

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2. Return-to-Play (EHS). After Exertional Heat Stroke, clearance by a physician experienced in sports medicine is required. Return-to-play must follow a supervised, gradual progression over at least 7-14 days, starting with light activity in cool environments.

E. Training and Incident Reporting.

1. Staff Training. All coaches, athletic trainers, and relevant staff must complete the National Federation of High School Associations (NFHS) Heat Illness Prevention course through NFHS Learn, or an equivalent approved training course on heat illness prevention. Training must include proper hydration and acclimatization guidelines and environmental monitoring procedures.

2. Reporting. Any case of a heat-related illness requiring medical removal from activity must be reported by the athletic trainer or coach to the school administration and parent/guardian within 24 hours.

3. Investigation. Severe incidents requiring emergency medical treatment or resulting in death shall be investigated by the Superintendent or designee, in collaboration with the VDOE and VHSL.

LCPS shall implement this policy by appropriate guidance.

Adopted: 5/12/26

Leg Refs.: Code of Virginia, 1950, as amended, §§ [22.1-271.9](#), [22.1-271.10](#), Virginia Board of Education Guidelines for Policies on Heat Related Illness Prevention in Student Athletes, VHSL, and NFHS Heat Illness Prevention Course.